

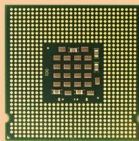


FOCUS ON... GOLD

This metal has a wide range of modern practical applications.



▲ Gold coins, such as this Byzantine one from around 600 CE, have been used as currency throughout history.



▲ The most reliable microchips have gold connections that rarely corrode or fail.



▲ The domes of some buildings, such as Brunei's Jame'Asr Hassanil Bolkiah Mosque, are covered in gold.

Gold

This precious metal is very soft and easy to shape. One cubic cm (0.06 cubic in) of gold can be drawn into a wire 165 m (540 ft) long without breaking, or hammered into 1 sq m (10 sq ft) of foil. Because of this, gold has been used extensively in making jewellery for thousands of years.

ATOMIC MASS 196.967

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY Around 3000 BCE

Nuggets such as this one are rare as most gold is found as dust mixed into rocks.

Nugget of pure gold



79
Au